I have neither aversion nor attachment, neither greed nor delusion;
Neither egotism nor envy, neither Dharma nor Moksha;
I am neither desire nor objects of desire;
I am Existence Absolute, Knowledge Absolute, Bliss
Absolute—I am Shiva, I am Shiva. (Shivoham, Shivoham).

I am neither sin nor virtue, neither pleasure nor pain; Nor
temple nor worship, nor pilgrimage nor scriptures, Neither
the act of enjoying, the enjoyable nor the enjoyer;
I am Existence Absolute, Knowledge Absolute, Bliss
Absolute—I am Shiva, I am Shiva. (Shivoham, Shivoham).

I have neither death nor fear of death, nor caste;
Nor was I ever born, nor had I parents, friends, and relations;
I have neither Guru, nor disciple;
I am Existence Absolute, Knowledge Absolute, Bliss
Absolute—I am Shiva, I am Shiva. (Shivoham, Shivoham).

I am untouched by the senses, I am neither Mukti nor knowable;
I am without form, without limit, beyond space, beyond time;
I am in everything; I am the basis of the universe; everywhere am I.
I am Existence Absolute, Knowledge Absolute, Bliss
Absolute—I am Shiva, I am Shiva. (Shivoham, Shivoham).

— Adi Shankara, *Nirvana Shatakam*[3]

All of this may seem somewhat abstruse to some, a sort of Hindu theological primer of no interest to most Hindus, let alone others. In fact there is far greater complexity to Advaita Vedanta than my simple summary can even begin to hint at. The *Kena Upanishad* makes that clear:

I do not think that I know it well. Nor do I know that I do not know it.
Among us those who know, know it; even they do not know that they do not know.

— *Kena Upanishad*, II.2[4]

However, there was the dawning realisation, among many of those who followed in his footsteps in the centuries following Adi Shankara's death in the mountain temple of Kedarnath at the young age of thirty-two, that there was a great need to make his breakthroughs intelligible to the common man. There were other even more compelling reasons for the faith to change and evolve.

REINVENTING HINDUISM